Islamabad, a geographical proximity to the capital of Pakistan that is often considered a matter of concern.

The roots of this militant group of Swat could be traced back to the late 1980s when Maulvi Fazlullah's father-in-law Sufi Muhammad formed an organisation Tehreek-e-Nifaz-e-Shariat-e-Mohammadi (TNSM) or the Movement for the Establishment of the Law of Prophet Muhammad, a *Wahabi* group, in Swat to strive to enforce his brand of *Sharia* in the area. In a bid to achieve this objective, TNSM posed several threats in the 1990s, including taking over the local airport and blocking the highway connecting Pakistan and China (*The Nation*, 2009). Its motto was *shariat ya shahadat* (Islamic laws or martyrdom). As Sufi states: 'Those opposing the imposition of *sharia* in Pakistan are *wajibulqatl* (worth being killed).' TNSM denounced democracy as un-Islamic (*The News International*, 2009).

In 2001, Sufi raised a *lashkar* (militia) of ill-equipped and untrained Mujahideen to support in the fight of Afghan Taliban against the US invasion. The *lashkar* was annihilated by the US air attacks and the brutal Northern Alliance forces. Sufi retreated but was arrested by the government of Pakistan and imprisoned (*The Nation*, 2009). He was released only in 2008 at the initiative of the Awami National Party government in NWFP to broker a peace deal between the government and Maulvi Fazlullah's militant group. He was again imprisoned on 30 July 2009 when a Swat police station had accused him of hate speech against the government, in which he had termed the Constitution of Pakistan 'un-Islamic' and demanded enforcement of the *Sharia*. He was released nine years later on the orders of the Peshawar High Court on 14 January 2018.

During imprisonment, in 2015, Sufi Muhammad issued an informal decree against his son-in-law Maulana Fazlullah-led Tehreek-e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP), declaring that its members lacked the traits essential for a Muslim.

'They {TTP} do not come up to the definition of *Momin* and Muslim set by the Holy Prophet (PBUH),' he stated in a written 'will'.

After his release from the jail, he again accused Maulana Fazlullah of bringing bad name to the TNSM, killing a number of its leaders and inflicting colossal loss on seminaries (DAWN, 15 January 2018).

The loosely organised TNSM and its offshoots were still strong in the Matta tehsil of Swat and in villages on the banks of the Swat River.